

Keep in mind that airlines can change their domestic fares up to three times a day. They usually do this at approximately 10:00AM, 12:30PM, and 8:00PM eastern standard time, and once on the weekend at 5:00PM. International fares can change once a day. It takes the search engines a few hours to respond to these changes.

A trend-based search engine is the best way to get a sense of when it's cheap to fly. FareCompare.com searches historical records of fares to give price trends for your itinerary. AirFare WatchDog.com is a great site that will email sales and alerts for a specific airport or route. While limited in scope, these services can help determine when the best time to buy a ticket might be.

If your itinerary is flexible, you have the luxury to choose the time and day that provides the cheapest ticket. If your schedule is more rigid, it is advisable to book your ticket either around a month in advance, or immediately before the flight, for the best price. While there is an availability gamble involved, the price usually reaches its lowest point in the last 24 hours before the flight.

3. Take matters into your own hands

Once you have a good sense of the fares that are turning up in the da-

tabase, contact the airline directly to ask if they can do any better. Be sure to ask if they have any special deals applicable to your specific route, as airlines will often give huge discounts to fliers willing to make an airport transfer, or use minor hubs.

An example of this is Air India, which gives huge discounts on the less popular trans-Atlantic leg of their flights to India. As another example, I used to consistently save \$100–\$200 flying to Europe by phoning the British Airways ticketing office and telling them I was willing to make the Heathrow to Gatwick transfer. Sadly, this deal is no more, but that does not mean that there are not others like it waiting to be found.

Finally, most regional airlines do not use the national database of the larger airlines. As a result, using only Internet search engines might miss some great deals on connecting flights. There is nothing stopping you from calling these airlines directly and piecing your itinerary together yourself. — **David DeFranza**

